traditions and celebrating each other’s festivals. At this time, both beef and pork were dropped from the Kashmiri diet.

In 1752, five years before the victory of the British East India Company in Plassey, the Durranis from Afghanistan seized Jammu and Kashmir from a weakened Mughal Empire. The Mughals had annexed the state from the Sultan dynasty in 1586 and politically incorporated it into their empire and ruled it for 166 years.

The minority Hindu community of Kashmiri Pandits or Brahmins were highly educated in the Persian language, and this knowledge helped them serve the state’s Muslim rulers for centuries and emerge as the cornerstone of the ruling dynasties. The Muslims in the state were mainly artisans and peasants. There was a clear trade-off—the Pandits accepted the dominant Islamic culture, but they controlled the state’s economy by virtue of their superior education and mobility.

The entire state of Jammu and Kashmir, as it stood in 1947 on the eve of Partition, was a constituent part of Maharaja Ranjit Singh’s kingdom of Punjab till as late as 1846. Maharaja Ranjit Singh had wrested Jammu and Kashmir from the declining Durrani Empire in 1819. This brought the state under a non-Muslim ruler for the first time in 455 years.

Emergence of Gulab Singh

When Maharaja Ranjit Singh conquered the state in 1819, he recognised the talents of one of his soldiers called Gulab Singh, a Dogra from Jammu. The Maharaja installed him as the ruler of Jammu in 1822 and personally anointed him as his vassal ruler.